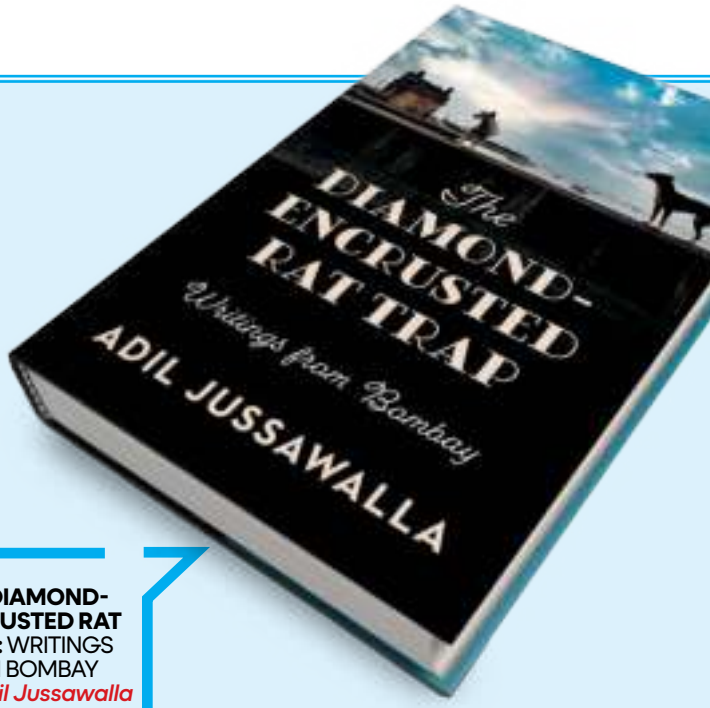
BOOKS ▼

City Snapshots

Best known for his poetry, ADIL JUSSAWALA shows his prose chops in this collection of pieces on Bombay/ Mumbai



THE DIAMOND-ENCRUSTED RAT TRAP: WRITINGS FROM BOMBAY
By Adil Jussawalla
SPEAKING TIGER
₹**499; 160** pages

There are many things that *The Diamond-Encrusted Rat Trap* does not do. It does not tell a comprehensive story of Mumbai. It does not pretend to capture the soul of the city, or even to understand its moods and mysteries.

This slim and occasionally eccentric volume—made up of a collection of Adil Jussawalla's prose pieces about Bombay-Mumbai—does something else altogether. It records the fleeting moments that add both beauty and horror to our city. In it, we encounter a city that "smells of the powder on the carrom board" and reverberates with the "sledgehammers of demolition crews". Where life often involves moving through a "box within box above box out of box inside box".

"The pieces gathered here do not attempt to understand Mumbai-Bombay...," writes Jerry Pinto in his Introduction. "They are a way of giving witness to the bigness and the strangeness of the city.... His city is built of chance encounters, of laughing liftmen, of departed friends and other ghosts." Jussawalla has shared a complex relationship with Mumbai. He left Bombay for London in 1957, seeking somewhere grander than the grey, peeling city of his birth. Thirteen years later, he returned to this place of stray dogs and Gokulashtami pot-breakers. After which he stayed on to write poetry, edit newspapers and magazines and observe his city by the sea.



A STRANGER IN THREE WORLDS
By Aubrey Menen
SPEAKING TIGER
₹**499; 280** pages

BOOKS ▼

MASTER OF THE FORM

AUBREY MENEN STRADDLED SEVERAL CULTURES AND IT'S THIS LIMINAL SPACE THAT INFORMS HIS WRITING

Aubrey Menen was born in England in 1912 to an Irish mother and an Indian father, a doctor—and brought up as an Englishman. The mixed upbringing makes him a stranger in three cultures, or the very opposite—an insider-outsider, which lends a unique flavour to his writing: a sage-like perspicacity and playful literary acuity mark every sentence. This edition is a two-in-one boombox—*Dead Man in the Silver Market* (1953) and *Space Within the Heart* (1970)—that jolts the reader awake.

MENEN'S **WRITING VOICE IS INVOLVED** YET MAINTAINS AN ARM'S DISTANCE—IT'S BOTH PARTICIPANT AND OBSERVER

The autobiographical essays here are classics of the genre. In 'My Grandmother and the Dirty English', we meet his maternal grandmother who considers herself superior to the British in all aspects: bathing ritual, food habits, even furniture: "she disliked chairs and thought them vulgar." In 'The Dead Man in